seats in the Bangladeshi Parliament, a clear two-thirds majority.

Among the foreign dignitaries present at Rahman's swearing-in was Om Birla, Speaker of the Lok Sabha, deputed to represent India. His presence, understated but deliberate, stood out at a time when India-Bangladesh relations have plumbed their nadir, especially under the Yunus-led interim regime. It was also a statement of India's intent that the past will not colour its relationship with the present dispensation. Or, as an expert put it, "The big message was that India was willing to engage and do business with a regime that now has the full mandate of its people." Even before Rahman was formally sworn in as premier, Prime Minister Narendra Modi called to congratulate him on his "remarkable victory", following it up with a post on X, "As two close neighbours with deep-rooted historical and cultural ties, I reaffirmed India's continued commitment to the peace, progress, and prosperity of both our peoples."

OM BIRLA'S PRESENCE AT RAHMAN'S SWEARING-IN SENT THE SIGNAL THAT INDIA WON'T LET THE PAST COLOUR ITS TIES WITH THE PRESENT REGIME

For India, there are indeed many positives from the outcome of the just-concluded Bangladesh election. The result reflects a stable mandate, driven largely by aspirational youth seeking development and employment. "This election has saved Bangladesh from dangerous uncertainties—political, economic and ideological," says Mahfuz Anam, editor of *The Daily Star* and a respected columnist. "People have voted for a centrist Bangladesh and not an extremist one. There may have been a significant rise in the religious vote, but the indication is clear: the people want the government to be run under secular and modern laws and not by religious diktat."

OLD TENSIONS

A stable Bangladesh can only be good news for India, especially as there were no anti-India hashtags or rhetoric during the campaign. The Gen Z-led revolt in August 2024 ended Hasina's reign of more than 15 years, forcing her to flee to India and plunged the country into uncertainty. It also marked the end of the strong bilateral relationship India enjoyed with Bangladesh under Hasina. Yunus, who took over as chief advisor of the interim dispensation, sought every opportunity "to smite India", according to an Indian expert on Bangladesh.

India was charged with aiding and abetting Hasina's "dictatorial rule" and ignoring her government's brutal crackdown on protesting students before she was ousted. The fact that India subsequently gave Hasina shelter saw the interim regime

INDO-BANGLA TIES

THE POINTS OF CONTENTION

A new dispensation in Dhaka gives India a fresh chance to resolve long-standing disputes with its neighbour



BSF personnel at the border, South Dinajpur, West Bengal

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ILLEGAL IMMIGRATION ↑

Illegal crossings were an issue even before Bangladesh was born, but the Centre's current concern is Myanmar's Rohingya refugees adding to the problem. Waves of migration down the decades have led to demographic changes in parts of Assam, Tripura and West Bengal, triggering ethnic tensions. Across the border, anti-India sentiment is fuelled by the BSF's strong-arm measures and the resultant human casualties. Since May 2025, India has also deported over 2,000 Bengali-speaking 'migrants', sparking a legal and political backlash.



← INSURGENCY

What India will want most is assurances that the BNP regime will not repeat the follies of the past and extend support to Northeast separatist outfits such as the ULFA (Assam) and the NSCN (Nagaland) again. The Awami League government crackdown since 2009 had put a stop to that with many top ULFA leaders arrested and deported. **Paresh Barua**, leader of the anti-talks ULFA faction, is still out there, likely holed up on the Myanmar-Bangladesh border.